

Lesson 6 · Microsoft Semantic Kernel (C# / .NET)

PDF: [this lesson](#) · **Install (Linux · macOS · Windows):** [guide](#) · [PDF](#)

Part of [local-ai-lab](#) — a hands-on course for building local AI.

Course home: <https://nikolareljin.github.io/local-ai-lab/> **Source:** <https://github.com/nikolareljin/local-ai-lab>

Lessons: [1 · RAG](#) → [2 · MCP](#) → [3 · LangChain](#) → [4 · LangGraph](#) → [5 · Ollama tools](#) → **6 · Semantic Kernel (you are here)** → [7 · Bedrock Agents](#) → [8 · Google ADK](#)

Status: planned. Outline below; full published slideshow lesson + step-by-step coming later. This is the course's **first C# / .NET lesson**, and it **runs locally** (against Ollama or a local OpenAI-compatible endpoint). [Join](#) the repo to follow along.

The idea

So far the course has been Python. **Microsoft Semantic Kernel (SK)** is the leading agent SDK for the **.NET / C#** world (with Python and Java ports). In this lesson you rebuild the document agent in C#, learning SK's model: a **Kernel**, **plugins** (your functions), and **automatic function calling**.

If you've done [Lesson 5](#), you'll recognize the shape — SK's plugins are function calling with batteries included and strong typing.

What you'll learn

- **The Kernel** — SK's composition root; registering AI services and plugins
- **Connectors** — wiring SK to a **local** model (Ollama / OpenAI-compatible) so nothing leaves your machine
- **Native plugins** — exposing a C# method as a tool with `[KernelFunction]` (your `SearchDocs`)
- **Automatic function calling** — `FunctionChoiceBehavior.Auto()` so the model calls plugins on its own
- **Prompt + planning** — templated prompts and how SK orchestrates multi-step calls

The design we'll build

```
using Microsoft.SemanticKernel;
using System.ComponentModel;

// A native plugin: the C# equivalent of Lesson 1's retriever as a tool.
public class DocsPlugin
{
    [KernelFunction, Description("Search the user's local documents for relevant passages.")]
```

```
public string SearchDocs([Description("What to search for")] string query)
    => DocsIndex.Search(query, k: 5); // returns "[source:page] text" blocks
}

var builder = Kernel.CreateBuilder();
builder.AddOpenAIChatCompletion( // point at a LOCAL endpoint
    modelId: "llama3.1",
    endpoint: new Uri("http://localhost:11434/v1"),
    apiKey: "ollama");
builder.Plugins.AddFromType<DocsPlugin>();
var kernel = builder.Build();

var settings = new OpenAIPromptExecutionSettings {
    FunctionChoiceBehavior = FunctionChoiceBehavior.Auto()
};
var answer = await kernel.InvokePromptAsync(
    "How do I reset the device? Cite sources.", new(settings))
```

The through-line: `DocsPlugin.SearchDocs` is the same `search_docs` capability from Lessons 1, 2 and 5 — just expressed in idiomatic C#. The concept is portable; only the syntax changes.

Builds on

Concept	From
a search tool the model can call	Lesson 5
grounding + citations	Lesson 1
plugins, kernel, auto function calling in C#	Lesson 6 (this one)

Prerequisites

.NET 8 SDK; a local model endpoint (Ollama's OpenAI-compatible API, or LM Studio). Concepts from [Lesson 5](#) help but aren't required.

Next lesson

[Lesson 7 · AWS Bedrock Agents →](#)